

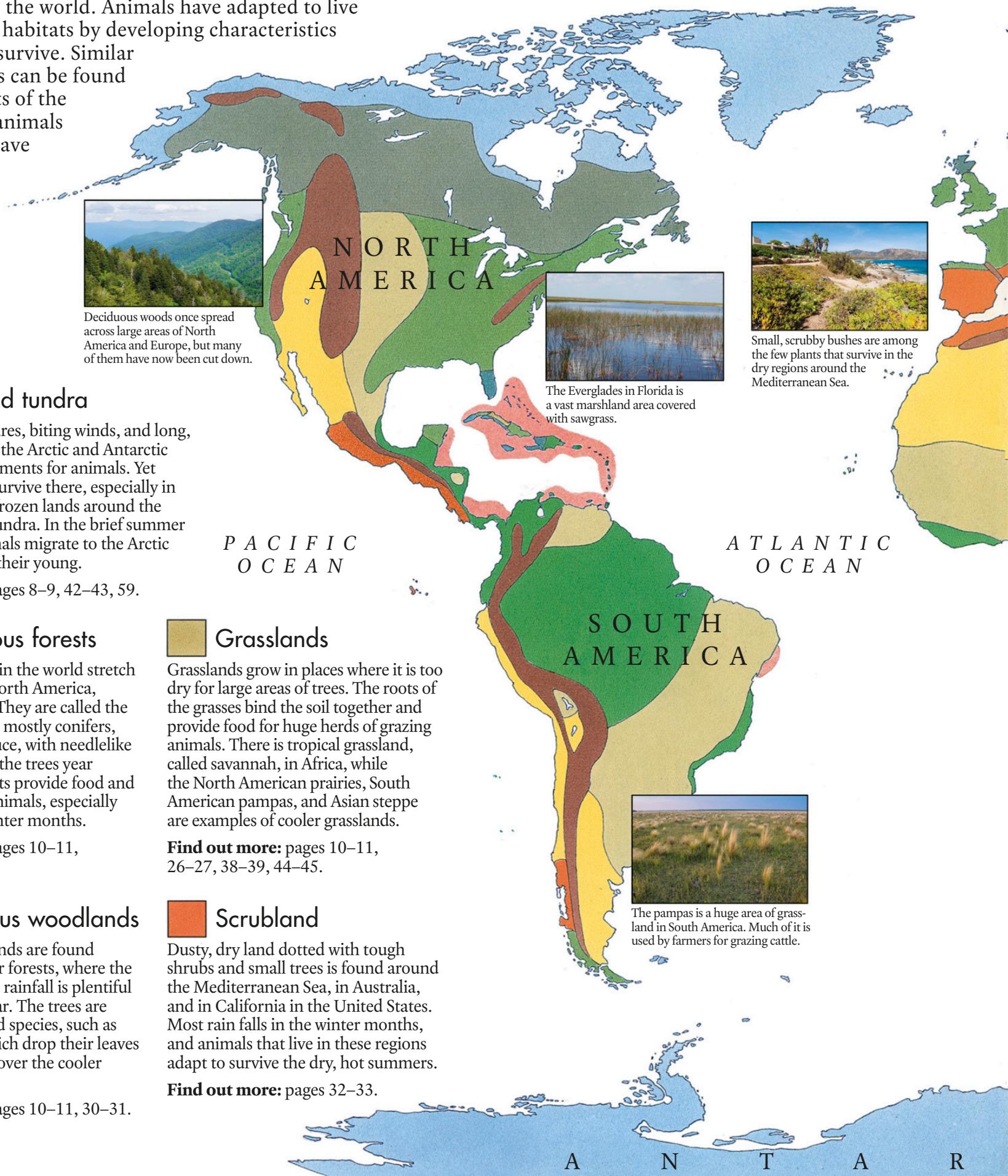
Animal Habitats

ANIMALS LIVE ALL OVER THE WORLD, from the frozen Arctic to hot deserts. The place where an animal lives is called its habitat. Many species can live together in the same habitat because they eat different kinds of food or make their homes in different places. The animal life in any habitat is a finely balanced mixture of species, and this balance can easily be disturbed.

The map on these two pages shows the main types of habitats around the world. Animals have adapted to live in each of these habitats by developing characteristics that help them survive. Similar types of habitats can be found in different parts of the world, and the animals that live there have

adapted in similar ways. For instance, the kit fox that lives in the North American deserts looks very similar to the fennec fox that lives in the Sahara Desert.

Physical barriers, such as mountains and seas, prevent many animals from moving freely from one place to another. Some, however, can fly or swim, so they spread over large areas. Tortoises, for example, can swim or float great distances across the sea.



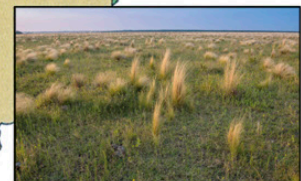
Deciduous woods once spread across large areas of North America and Europe, but many of them have now been cut down.



The Everglades in Florida is a vast marshland area covered with sawgrass.



Small, scrubby bushes are among the few plants that survive in the dry regions around the Mediterranean Sea.



The pampas is a huge area of grassland in South America. Much of it is used by farmers for grazing cattle.

Polar and tundra

The low temperatures, biting winds, and long, dark winters make the Arctic and Antarctic very harsh environments for animals. Yet many animals do survive there, especially in the seas or on the frozen lands around the Arctic, called the tundra. In the brief summer period, many animals migrate to the Arctic to breed and raise their young.

Find out more: pages 8–9, 42–43, 59.

Coniferous forests

The largest forests in the world stretch across the top of North America, Europe, and Asia. They are called the taiga. The trees are mostly conifers, such as fir and spruce, with needlelike leaves that stay on the trees year round. These forests provide food and shelter for many animals, especially during the cold winter months.

Find out more: pages 10–11, 28–29, 42–43.

Deciduous woodlands

Deciduous woodlands are found south of the conifer forests, where the climate is mild and rainfall is plentiful throughout the year. The trees are mostly broadleaved species, such as oak and beech, which drop their leaves in the fall and rest over the cooler winter months.

Find out more: pages 10–11, 30–31.

Grasslands

Grasslands grow in places where it is too dry for large areas of trees. The roots of the grasses bind the soil together and provide food for huge herds of grazing animals. There is tropical grassland, called savannah, in Africa, while the North American prairies, South American pampas, and Asian steppe are examples of cooler grasslands.

Find out more: pages 10–11, 26–27, 38–39, 44–45.

Scrubland

Dusty, dry land dotted with tough shrubs and small trees is found around the Mediterranean Sea, in Australia, and in California in the United States. Most rain falls in the winter months, and animals that live in these regions adapt to survive the dry, hot summers.

Find out more: pages 32–33.